

Culture as the Soul of Public Policy: Reimagining Good Governance, the Bharatiya Way

Public policy, at its best, is not just a blueprint for governance; it is a living architecture. The foundation is institutional design, the pillars are administrative capability, but the soul that animates it, stabilises it, and gives it legitimacy is culture. In India, this connection is not abstract; it is civilizational. Culture does not merely accompany public policy; it translates it, uplifts it, and often makes the difference between a well-drafted policy and a well-implemented one. If public policy is the structure, culture is the mortar and concrete that holds it together. And when culture and policy align, good governance becomes not just effective, it becomes distinctly and authentically Bharatiya.

Let's see why culture matters from a civilisational standpoint. For over 5,000 years, India has organised its public life not primarily through rigid institutions, but through lived traditions, Dharma, Nyaya, Panchayat sabhas, community water systems, grihastha-based economic ethics, and the powerful idea of Antyodaya. Scholars such as Amartya Sen, Kaushik Basu, and N.K. Singh have reiterated that India's development trajectory cannot be evaluated merely through Western institutional models; it must be interpreted through its cultural DNA. India's civilizational values, such as duty over entitlement (Dharma), community over individualism, frugality, co-existence, decentralisation, and ethical leadership are not ornamental. They are actionable governance principles. And India's best public policy successes emerge when these civilizational principles are consciously embedded into statecraft.

To realise this much better, let's examine a few examples from the current Indian governance model, demonstrating that when culture leads, policy succeeds. The first example is the Swachh Bharat Mission (SBM), where behaviour change was built on civilizational ethos. At its core, SBM succeeded not only because of financing or infrastructure but because it revived an ancient cultural idea, "Shuddhi" (purity), both internal and external. Behaviour change campaigns like "Darwaza Band" were effective because they reframed sanitation as a moral and social duty, deeply anchored in Gandhian philosophy, which itself drew from civilizational ethics of cleanliness. The World Bank noted that SBM is "the largest behavioural change programme ever attempted," possible only because culture, not enforcement, became the primary driver. To sum this up: culture translated policy into practice.

The second example is the Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM), where water governance is rooted in community traditions. India has an ancient culture of community water management, from Odisha's Katas to Rajasthan's Baoris to Karnataka's Kalyanis. JJM intentionally revived this decentralised philosophy. The mission's emphasis on Village Water and Sanitation Committees, women-led testing and monitoring, community ownership, and local water-source rejuvenation mirrors the civilizational ethos of "Jal is life, and life is collective." UNICEF and WHO reports highlight that JJM's sustainability is strong precisely because communities culturally view water as a shared responsibility, not merely a government service. Here, culture made the policy self-sustaining.

The third example is Digital Public Infrastructure (Aadhaar-UPI-DigiLocker), where frugality and trust become cultural capital. India's digital governance revolution rests on a distinctly Bharatiya cultural trait: frugal innovation, "doing more with less." The world describes this as "Jugaad," but policymakers have elevated it to a sophisticated architecture called the India Stack. The success of Aadhaar and UPI is not just technological; it draws from cultural factors such as high trust in government-led identity systems, openness to technology as a tool of social equity, comfort with shared community resources, and a cultural habit of "collective adjustment," enabling quick digital adoption. Reports from the IMF and MIT note that India's digital governance works because social trust and cultural adaptability are unusually high. It shows that culture accelerated adoption and ensured scale.

The fourth example is Mission LiFE, India's sustainability model. While global climate policy emphasises regulation, Mission LiFE focuses on lifestyle, rooted in India's civilizational teachings of Aparigraha (minimalism), Prakriti-Pujan (reverence for nature), and Samatva (balance). NITI Aayog and UNEP highlight that LiFE reframes climate change not as an external threat but as an internal behavioural responsibility, deeply compatible with Indian values. Here again, culture turned environmental policy into a people's movement.

The final example is Ayushman Bharat and Wellness Centres. The idea of "wellness" in India predates modern health policy by millennia, seen in Ayurvedic principles like Swasthya, Tridosha balance, and prevention over cure. By integrating yoga, preventive care, and community wellness into primary health centres, Ayushman Bharat expresses a cultural truth:

health is not just medical; it is holistic. WHO's endorsement of India's integrative health approach reflects this civilizational depth.

We can conclude this part by saying that policy without culture is a structure without a soul. For all its institutional sophistication, the state is most effective when it aligns with India's cultural imagination. A policy can be technically sound but socially resisted. A programme can be well-funded but weakly adopted. A reform can be globally acclaimed yet locally irrelevant. Culture fills this gap. It gives meaning, moral legitimacy, and collective ownership to public policy. As Kautilya wrote in the Arthashastra, "The root of governance is the welfare of the people, and the root of welfare is their acceptance." Acceptance emerges not from enforcement but from cultural resonance.

The future of good governance is becoming culturally literate. India stands at a moment when it can shape a governance model that the world can learn from, one that is modern yet civilizationally grounded. Our greatest strategic advantage is not technology, nor even economic scale, but our culture: the accumulated wisdom of millennia on how communities organise themselves, govern themselves, and sustain themselves. Policies give structure. Institutions give continuity. But culture gives life. For India to realise its full potential, our public policy must not only be evidence-based and efficient, it must be culturally rooted. Only then can good governance truly become good Bharatiya governance.